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Meritocracy and its Critics

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Is Meritocracy Just? Hard Work, Freedom, and Equality

Meritocracy is a societal system where people are sorted into positions of power, wealth, and status based on their abilities and merits. Through effort and achievement, meritocracy allows anyone to rise in wealth or social class. Yet despite the rise of meritocratic rhetoric in the United States since the 1980s, research data analysis from the Opportunity Insights project surprisingly indicates that the rate of social mobility has decreased and income inequality is rising (Chetty et al., 2016). Moreover, critics argue that meritocracy is causing political and social divisions and strain. Although meritocracy may encourage individual freedom and responsibility, meritocracy has some flaws because it leads to selfish competition and neglect of the common good. Instead, fostering a society with broad equality of conditions would be more just.

Many people today regard meritocracy as good because it enables anyone, regardless of their background, to rise in social class and wealth based on one's effort in improving one's abilities. The American Dream is the ideal that, with ingenuity and hard work, anyone can achieve the "rags to riches" story. Some organizations claim their workplaces are meritocratic, meaning that they hire and promote employees based on their skills and qualifications, not on privileged status or by discrimination. Fundamentally, meritocracy is about ranking and

rewarding people based on their abilities. Such system enables people who produce more to enjoy their fruits of their labor and thus incentivizes people to work.

While it would be nice if people donated generously their extra earnings to the poor, meritocracy has actually reduced altruism and public service. People are too preoccupied with competing with each other in the workplace and the global economy for limited resources. Since meritocracy enables people to rise above others in wealth and social status, people do not want to be left behind in the arms race of personal wealth and power. Workers in elite professions (such as finance, management, and law) are often overworked (Markovitz, 2019). This is because the company leaders want to win huge rewards from dominating the unfair winner-take-all market. Thus, meritocracy incentivizes solo achievement and disincentivizes helping others and the common good.

More than just making people busy competing, meritocracy engenders hubristic attitudes corrosive of the common good (Sandel, 2020). The winners of the meritocratic competition often assume they deserve their rewards because they worked hard to achieve them. Though they may recognize that some people have greater arbitrary advantages, what is important, they may argue, is making the most of one's limited resources and unique situation. People can adapt and grow wherever they are. People can work with others and apply knowledge and technology to create new enterprises. People have some control over their destiny. Society should promote such drive for human mastery and achievement. If society provides more financial support to the underprivileged, the competitive playing field will be more level and fairer, giving everyone equal opportunity to rise in social mobility. Even if one is unintelligent and unskilled, hard work will enable anyone to become educated, develop skills and talents, and succeed in almost any

endeavor. Thus, they conclude that the winners of the fair meritocratic competition deserve their rewards.

Although hard work can often make a big difference in one's life outcome, there are many factors beyond our control that shape our destiny. For example, some lucky students are born in wealthy homes with supportive parents who confer every advantage for the child's physical, intellectual, and emotional development. Being in the right place at the right time plays a huge role in shaping one's life outcome; for instance, had Bill Gates been born to poor parents in the desert of Africa, it is unlikely that he would have become a billionaire technology entrepreneur. Even small advantages and events during childhood can later have a great impact on people's personality and character. People who regard themselves as "self-made" often fail to recognize the many arbitrary advantages and community support they have gained.

In contrast, some unfortunate students are born with disabilities, without supportive parents or community (including facing discrimination), and little options other than lowly work (or none at all). Even with exposure to smart teachers or inspirational speeches, it is unlikely that the underprivileged students will take advantage of the resources to improve because they do not find the alien goal of mastery worth pursuing. Merely increasing funding to schools is unlikely to change outcomes of low socio-economic status students unless their family and community needs are met. Moreover, no matter how dedicated and hard-working, a person who is blind, for example, faces huge disadvantage in society. Thus, natural talents and life circumstances can be as arbitrarily unfair as being born in a wealthy and privileged family, which is what meritocracy is supposed to combat.

However, individuals who make big contributions to society may object that imposing a broad equality of conditions would violate people's rights to the fruits of their labor. For

example, Jeff Bezos, the founder of the e-commerce company Amazon and the richest person in the world with around $200 billion net worth, claims in the Amazon's 2020 Shareholders Letter that the company created $300 billion in value in the year 2020, including by saving each customer on average 75 hours a year in physical shopping time (Bezos, 2021). Bezos implies that Amazon should be allowed to be distinctive from other companies and deserves its towering rewards. If government were to interfere and redistribute Amazon's wealth, Bezos worries that "the universe" would unjustly "make us typical" and "smooth you into your surroundings," which would stifle individual liberty and diversity (Bezos, 2021).

Although Amazon did create great value for many people and may deserve somewhat greater rewards than others, Bezos should be humbler by recognizing the company's good luck and the many ways the world community has helped Amazon. Bezos may argue that he worked very hard, smart, and long; he made many personal and family sacrifices for what he ultimately wanted; and he paid his fair share of taxes and reciprocated all the help he'd received (such as by donating to his school and community). Yet Bezos should realize that he was very lucky in many ways: he was born healthy and intelligent with a supportive family and community (with peace, law, and infrastructure); the internet business market conditions were favorable; and technology enabled him to multiply his productivity and dominate an imperfect winner-take-all market. With these many advantages, it seems doubtful that Bezos merits more than one thousand times the wealth of the median American worker (such as a nurse). Unless it is clear that Bezos' massive concentration of wealth is for the benefit of the least well-off members of society, Bezos may be claiming more money than he is due.

However, one may object that in a perfect meritocracy, where everyone has a truly equal opportunity to succeed, hardworking people deserve to keep most of their rewards. For instance,

let's assume that there are two farmers with similar physical strength and quality of land and resources. Farmer A works much harder and longer every day, and she ingeniously devises a novel way to apply agricultural technology to increase her crop yield, enabling her to bring greater happiness to and grow her family. In contrast, Farmer B is lazy and profligate, and he just plays video games all day, hoping others will support him. In this case, hard work, which is within one's control, is the main differentiator in life outcome. Therefore, it seems unfair for the government to force the hardworking Farmer A to give up much of her wealth to help the lazy Farmer B. The mandatory wealth distribution seems to violate Farmer A's liberty and property rights. Thus, one may argue that a meritocracy allocates rewards fairly and efficiently based on how hard one is willing to work.

Although it would be fair for the hard-working Farmer A to deserve considerably more than the slothful Farmer B to incentivize work, it would still be ethical for the government to seize Farmer A's wealth to establish a broad equality of conditions. The first reason is that the system of the perfect meritocracy is flawed because it excessively valorizes hard work over other important human values. To rise to the top of the social and economic ladder, a meritocracy demands that one work the hardest and smartest. Thus, life merely becomes a demanding competition of who expends the most energy and thinks most cleverly to win. Since Farmer A expends 10,000 calories of energy a day while Farmer B only spends only 100 calories, one may reason illogically that Farmer A deserves one hundred times greater rewards than Farmer B because she expended one hundred times more energy of work. Yet our society should not be merely a meritocratic energy-expenditure competition for maximizing personal wealth. In such world, humanity is reduced to a primal state, akin to animals always racing against each other for food and resources. While self-improvement through hard work is respectable, there should be

limits to how much one can earn from hard work because society should also value important qualities like compassion and dignity.

Also, in the future, hard work will not matter much in shaping life outcomes. In our technological age where machine automation may displace 25% of human jobs by the year 2030, relying on hard work as a metric of moral desert will soon no longer be possible because there may not be enough jobs to go around (McKinsey report, 2019). There will likely then be even more fierce competition for a few high-skill jobs, and those without college degrees will be left without a source of income, which would likely lead to social unrest and upheaval. It would be unfair for clever elites to hoard capital and solely control the means of production and technology (including artificial intelligence). Such dystopian future may arise because meritocracy does not address the underlying problem of social inequality. Thus, it is important to democratize knowledge, wealth and power and enforce a broad equality of conditions for fairness and safety.

A second reason against a perfect meritocracy is that a competitive society discourages collaboration and exhausts everyone in an arms race (Sandel, 2020). Instead of always competing against one another, if we work together as humanity, we can accomplish much more. For example, it is a waste of time and energy for people to have to spend their whole lives on competing to get into a prestigious college, job, and social status; instead, people should be free to pursue one's passions and community service. Similarly, if the United States and Russia stopped worrying about competing with each other (like in the Cold War) and instead focused on teaming up to fight poverty, there would be much greater social progress. While it would feel nice and secure for one country or person to have absolute power, a dictatorship may lead to tyranny and abuse of power. Thus, though this may be more uncomfortable, a democracy enables

diverse people to deliberate together towards an agreeable social arrangement. In our increasingly interdependent and small world (with overpopulation and limited resources), it is ever more important to live together peacefully. Thus, it is sometimes just for government to prevent one individual or group from accumulating too much power and wealth.

Finally, dismantling meritocracy and establishing a broad equality of conditions is justified because helping the least-advantaged members of society is morally good because doing so would respect their dignity and human rights to a decent life. Even if the marginalized poor are ungrateful or underserving, it is virtuous to help them and show mercy and love. We should be compassionate towards their difficult life situations and more understanding of human weakness and sin. Indeed, we have less control over our lives and fate than we may think. We should be grateful for God's grace and the generosity and sacrifices that people have made for us. Instead of worrying about punishing lazy people, we should focus on equipping them with the resources to live comfortably and contribute to their communities. While it is fair to enforce individual responsibility up to a certain point, what is more needed in our society is collective responsibility to ensure everyone can live with dignity (Sandel, 2020). A good society is not demanding but is loving.

Although meritocracy may seem liberating, it can become tyrannizing by forcing people to compete against each other and work strenuously to survive. The race for individual achievement creates hubris among the smart and skilled winners and disrespects the dignity of those left behind. This leads to widening social inequality and neglect of the common good. Instead, a just society establishes a broad equality of conditions and balances individual freedom with collective responsibility. Humility and gratitude can inspire joy in helping others.

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